CHINHOYI UNIVERSITY OF TECHNOLOGY · ABF-FST RESEARCH STUDY

Research Assistant Training Programme

A three-day programme to prepare Research Assistants for ABF-FST fieldwork: schedule, session plans, role-plays, assessment and sign-off.

STUDY	Developing and Validating the Agribusiness Bankability Framework for Food Systems Transformation through Novel Financing Models in Zimbabwe (ABF-FST)
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FOR	The PI and Field Coordinator (facilitators)
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*Screenshots in this document use **fictional demonstration data**. Organisation and person names, phone numbers and figures shown in them are not real study records.*

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1. Programme overview

This programme prepares every Research Assistant (RA) to work on the ABF-FST study safely, ethically and consistently, using the Digital Respondent Portal and KoboToolbox. It combines a shared foundation (Day 1), role-specific tracks (Day 2) and realistic practice with assessment (Day 3), followed by a supervised first week.

Participants	Contact RAs, QUAN/Kobo QA RAs, KII RAs and Documentary RAs. Field Coordinators attend as co-facilitators.
Facilitators	Happyson Saina (PI) and the Field / Digital Coordinator.
Duration	3 days (about 6.5 hours of contact time a day), plus pre-work and a supervised first week.
Group size	Up to 16 trainees; track groups of 2–6.
Materials	RA Training Manual (every trainee), the Role Guide for each trainee's role, the System Manual (facilitators), the Respondent Guide, one laptop or tablet per trainee, and a phone with WhatsApp.
Outcome	Each trainee is assessed as competent for their role, signs the confidentiality declaration, and receives their own portal account.

1.1 Learning objectives

By the end of the programme each RA will be able to:

- Explain the study, its voluntary nature and the fact that it produces no score or financing decision, in plain language.
- Obtain and record informed consent correctly, and handle refusals and withdrawals respectfully.
- Protect personal data in line with the study's data protection protocol and the Cyber and Data Protection Act.
- Use the portal screens for their role accurately, and record every action where it belongs.
- Apply the study's quality rules, and write notes that another person can understand and audit.
- Recognise when to escalate to the Field Coordinator or PI.

1.2 Before the training (facilitator checklist)

When	Task	Who
2 weeks before	Confirm trainees, roles and provinces; fill in the staff accounts template	PI
1 week before	Create accounts (create_staff_accounts); prepare the practice site and practice cases (see 1.3)	PI / administrator
1 week before	Send each trainee the RA Training Manual and their Role Guide as pre-reading	FC
3 days before	Print confidentiality declarations, attendance register, assessment sheets	FC
Day before	Test projector, Wi-Fi, the practice site, the study WhatsApp number on a demo phone	FC

1.3 The practice environment

Trainees must never practise on real respondents. Use one of these, in order of preference:

1. **Practice site (recommended).** The administrator makes the scrubbed staging copy of the portal available for the training days. It holds the study's shape without any real names or numbers. It is not publicly reachable today, so ask the administrator at least a week ahead. Trainees sign in with practice accounts and may send test invitations to their own phones.
2. **Demonstration only.** If the practice site is unavailable, the facilitator demonstrates on the practice copy while trainees follow in the manual, and trainees practise with paper exercises and role-play.

> **Never on the live system, never a real submission**
> Do not issue invitations, record respondents or take QA decisions on the live portal during training. Live records are real research data, and every action is audited under the trainee's name.
>
> The KoboToolbox forms are the live study forms. In practice, respondents stop before submitting the questionnaire, and KII and document exercises are recorded in the portal only. A practice submission would land in the real data.

2. Schedule

Day 1 — Foundations (all RAs)

Time	Session	Lead	Group
08:30	Welcome, introductions, programme and ground rules	PI	All
09:00	Module 1 — The ABF-FST study: purpose, design, targets and timeline	PI	All
10:00	Module 2 — Research ethics: voluntary participation, informed consent, PIS v1.5	PI	All
11:00	Break		
11:15	Module 3 — Data protection and confidentiality (Cyber and Data Protection Act, POTRAZ)	PI / FC	All
12:15	Module 4 — Professional conduct, study WhatsApp number, device security	FC	All
13:00	Lunch		
14:00	Module 5 — The portal: signing in, your screens, roles, statuses, audit trail (live demo)	FC	All
15:15	Module 6 — The respondent journey on a phone (walk-through as a respondent)	FC	All
16:00	Module 7 — KoboToolbox forms: Questionnaire, KII Guide, Document tool	PI / FC	All
16:45	Day 1 check: quiz part A, questions, reading for Day 2	FC	All

Day 2 — Role tracks

Time	Session	Lead	Group
08:30	Recap of Day 1; account sign-in check for every trainee	FC	All
09:00	Track sessions (parallel groups) — see the track plans below	Track lead	By role
11:00	Break		
11:15	Track sessions continue: guided practice on the practice site	Track lead	By role
13:00	Lunch		
14:00	Module 8 — Communication skills: introductions, gatekeepers, objections, refusals	PI / FC	Contact, KII
14:00	Module 9 — Quality judgement: evidence, notes, consistency	PI	QA, Documentary
15:30	Track practice: individual exercises with feedback	Track lead	By role
16:45	Day 2 check: quiz part B (role-specific)	FC	All

Track content

Track	Covers	Materials
Contact RA	Finding the right person; recording respondents and numbers; sending invitations on WhatsApp, SMS and email; the WhatsApp invitations queue; logging every attempt; Follow-ups; Appointments; assisted interviews; refusals and withdrawals	Role Guide 3; Manual Module A
QUAN/Kobo QA RA	QA Dashboard; reading a completed form PDF; the QA rules; Accept / Re-query / Reject with good notes; working QA exceptions; Sync now	Role Guide 4; Manual Module B
KII RA	KII records and statuses; participation and recording consent; conducting the interview; Executive Short Form (K1, K2, K3, K7, K9); transcript and coding progress; KII Guide in KoboToolbox	Role Guide 5; Manual Module C
Documentary RA	Recording a source precisely; judging authenticity; Include / Exclude; interpretive memos; the Document Analysis Tool (Exclude skips Sections C–L); attaching or removing a source file; Auto-fill and how to review an AI draft	Role Guide 6; Manual Module D

Day 3 — Practice and assessment

Time	Session	Lead	Group
08:30	Role-play rotations: the 10 scenarios in Section 4	PI / FC	All
10:30	Break		
10:45	Field simulation: a full case from assignment to QA decision, in teams	FC	All
12:30	Debrief: what went wrong, what to do differently	PI	All
13:00	Lunch		
14:00	Practical assessment (observed tasks) and written assessment	PI / FC	All
15:30	Confidentiality declaration, account hand-over, first-week plan	PI	All
16:15	Certification and close	PI	All

After the training

When	Activity
First week of fieldwork	Each RA works with the Field Coordinator checking their first 5 cases (or first 5 QA decisions, KIIs or documents) before continuing alone.
Daily, first two weeks	15-minute stand-up: what's blocked, questions, refusals, anything unusual.
Weekly	Team debrief using Reports: response rate, coverage, QA flags, follow-ups backlog.
When rules change	Short refresher, and the manuals are re-issued with a new version number.

3. Session plans

Each plan lists objectives, method and what the trainee should be able to show at the end. Timings are guides.

Module 1 — The study (60 min)

- **Objective:** trainees can explain the study in two minutes, to a busy manager.
- **Content:** study title and purpose; Main-400 and Reserve-400; 400 questionnaires, 60 KIIs, 50–75 documents; data lock on 30 November 2026; what the portal does and does not do.
- **Method:** short presentation (System Manual chapter 2), then pairs practise the two-minute explanation.
- **Check:** each trainee gives the explanation without notes, including 'voluntary' and 'no score or financing decision'.

Module 2 — Research ethics and consent (60 min)

- **Objective:** trainees can obtain informed consent correctly in person, by phone and on WhatsApp.
- **Content:** Participant Information Sheet v1.5, point by point; voluntary participation; right to stop and withdraw; separate KII recording consent; what counts as consent in the portal.
- **Method:** read the PIS together; demonstrate a consent conversation; trainees practise in threes (respondent, RA, observer with checklist).
- **Check:** observer checklist complete for every trainee.

Module 3 — Data protection (60 min)

- **Objective:** trainees handle personal data lawfully and safely.
- **Content:** what counts as personal data; using contact details only for this study; the study WhatsApp number; screen locks; no screenshots or forwarding; lost devices; withdrawal; access requests go to the PI.
- **Method:** discussion of the data rules (Manual Section 3), then 'spot the breach' cards.
- **Check:** each trainee identifies at least 5 of the 6 breaches on the cards.

Module 5 — The portal (75 min)

- **Objective:** trainees sign in and find every screen for their role.
- **Content:** sign-in, Change password, navigation, registers and search, the case page, statuses S00–S16, the audit trail.
- **Method:** live demonstration, then each trainee signs in to the practice site and completes Exercise 1.
- **Check:** every trainee has changed their practice password and found their screens.

Module 6 — The respondent journey (45 min)

- **Objective:** trainees know exactly what respondents see.

- **Content:** Respondent Guide; confirmation, eligibility, information, consent, choice of how to take part, questionnaire, appointment, thank-you screen.
- **Method:** each trainee opens a practice invitation on their own phone and goes through it as a respondent, stopping at the questionnaire's first page (never submitting it).
- **Check:** trainees can answer the Respondent Guide's questions and answers without looking.

Module 8 — Communication skills (90 min)

- **Objective:** trainees handle introductions, gatekeepers, objections and refusals professionally.
- **Content:** call and WhatsApp scripts (Manual Section 5), tone, listening, never pressuring, recording the outcome.
- **Method:** demonstration, then role-play of scenarios 1–7.
- **Check:** observer feedback on each role-play.

Module 9 — Quality judgement (90 min)

- **Objective:** QA and Documentary RAs make consistent, well-explained decisions.
- **Content:** the QA rules; what makes a good note; evidence standards for documents; authenticity and inclusion.
- **Method:** trainees independently judge the same 5 examples, then compare and agree.
- **Check:** trainees agree on at least 4 of the 5, and every note is clear to another reader.

4. Role-plays and simulation

Run each scenario with three trainees: one plays the respondent (using the brief), one the RA, one observes with the checklist. Rotate roles.

Scenario	Respondent brief	What good looks like
1. The gatekeeper	A receptionist says the MD is busy and asks what this is about.	Explain briefly (university study, voluntary, 15–25 minutes); ask for the best person and a good time; record them as gatekeeper; log RESCHEDULED.
2. "Will this affect our loan?"	The finance manager worries answers reach the bank.	No score, rating or financing decision; answers never shared with any lender; results only reported combined and anonymised.
3. Wrong person	A junior officer received the link and wants to fill it in.	Thank them; only senior, knowledgeable roles take part; ask who that is; record and invite that person instead.
4. Refusal	The owner says they are not interested.	Thank them, don't persuade; log REFUSED with their words; tell the Field Coordinator the same day.
5. Withdrawal after submitting	A respondent who completed the questionnaire asks for their answers not to be used.	Stop contact; tell the Field Coordinator, who records the withdrawal; their answers are kept for the audit trail but never analysed.
6. Expired link	A respondent tries a link from three weeks ago.	Links last 14 days. Check the invitation history and send a new invitation (it replaces the old one).
7. Phone interview	A respondent prefers to answer by phone now.	Confirm organisation and role, read the information, get consent, then open their link and complete it with them (mode 03). Log COMPLETED.
8. KII recording	An informant agrees to the interview but not to recording.	Record participation consent only; take notes; do not tick Recording made; the portal refuses a recorded completion without recording consent.
9. QA: 3-minute questionnaire	A submission is flagged as too quick.	Open the PDF; look for straight-lining and blanks; Re-query with a specific note, or Accept only if the answers are credible — and say why.
10. Undated web source	A useful platform page has no visible date.	Record the URL and the date accessed; look for corroboration; mark Disputed if authorship or date can't be confirmed, with reasons in the memo.

Field simulation (Day 3)

1. Teams of four (one of each RA role) receive one practice case at S03.
2. The Contact RA records the respondent, sends the invitation to a teammate's phone and logs the attempt.
3. The teammate goes through the portal screens as a respondent and stops at the questionnaire's first page. The facilitator gives the QA RA a prepared practice submission with one planted problem (for example a very short completion).
4. The QA RA reviews it, works the exception and records a decision with a note.
5. The KII RA and Documentary RA each complete a practice record end to end in parallel.

6. The team presents what they did and where the audit trail shows it.

5. Assessment and certification

5.1 Competencies

Role	The trainee can…
All RAs	Signs in, changes password, signs out; finds screens; explains the study, voluntariness and 'no score' in their own words; applies the data rules; knows when to escalate
Contact RA	Records a respondent with a correctly formatted number; sends an invitation on the right channel; logs an attempt with outcome and note; sends a due reminder and marks it; handles a refusal and a withdrawal request correctly
QUAN/Kobo QA RA	Opens and reads a form PDF; identifies which rule fired and why; writes a decision note another person can follow; assigns and closes an exception with a note
KII RA	Records consent separately before starting; refuses to record without recording consent; moves the record correctly through statuses; runs the Executive Short Form within 15 minutes
Documentary RA	Records a source that someone else can find again; justifies Verified/Disputed; never includes an unassessed document; writes a useful memo

5.2 Written assessment (answer key)

Pass mark: 12 out of 15. Trainees below the pass mark repeat the relevant module and retake the questions they missed.

#	Question	Expected answer
1	How long is a personal invitation link valid?	14 days.
2	Name two things every invitation message contains.	The personal link and its expiry, the manual code, and the study contact line (any two).
3	When are the approved reminders due?	Day 2 and Day 7 after the invitation.
4	When may a case become S13 Nonresponse?	Only after every reminder has actually been sent (marked sent).
5	Which WhatsApp account must you send from?	The shared study WhatsApp number, never a personal one.
6	A respondent asks if their answers affect financing. What do you say?	No score, rating or financing decision is produced, and answers are never shared with lenders.
7	Who records a withdrawal in the portal?	The Field Coordinator or PI.
8	What happens to answers submitted before a withdrawal?	Kept for the audit trail, never analysed (left out of the analysis export).
9	What must be recorded before a KII is recorded on audio?	Separate recording consent (in addition to participation consent).
10	What are the QA duration limits?	Under 5 minutes or over 90 minutes is flagged.
11	Can a questionnaire pass QA automatically?	No. A person must select Accept and write a note.

#	Question	Expected answer
12	What must happen before a document can be Included?	Its authenticity must be assessed (Verified or Disputed).
13	What does 'This screen isn't part of your role' mean?	The screen belongs to another role; go back to your start screen or ask the PI.
14	Where do you record that you phoned someone?	Case page → Contact timeline → Log contact attempt.
15	What is the PI's phone number for respondents?	0773943709.

5.3 Practical assessment

Observe each trainee completing the tasks for their role on the practice site. Mark each competency as Competent or Not yet competent, with a comment. Everyone must be Competent on all their role's competencies before receiving a live account.

Trainee	Role	Written score	Practical	Declaration signed	Account issued	Assessor

6. Attendance register

Name	Role	Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Signature